

Primary Source Reading 2: Responses to the Problem of Evil

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) Texts unaltered, from four historical sources — see citations below each passage

Before you read: Centuries before Hume sharpened the Problem of Evil into its classic form, Christian thinkers had already been working out how to reconcile a good, all-powerful God with a world full of suffering. This reading gathers four short passages representing three distinct lines of response: Aquinas and Augustine on evil as a privation (an absence) rather than a created thing; Augustine on free will as a good great enough to be worth the risk of its misuse; and Irenaeus on the idea that human imperfection is part of a deliberate process of growth. None of these passages mention Hume — they could not, since two long predate him by over a thousand years — but each addresses exactly the question he presses.

Aquinas: Evil as Privation, Not as a Thing God Makes

From the Summa Theologica, Part I, Question 49, Article 2 — “Whether the supreme good, God, is the cause of evil?” Translated by the Fathers of the English Dominican Province (1920).

I answer that, As appears from what was said, the evil which consists in the defect of action is always caused by the defect of the agent. But in God there is no defect, but the highest perfection. Hence, the evil which consists in defect of action, or which is caused by defect of the agent, is not reduced to God as to its cause.

But the evil which consists in the corruption of some things is reduced to God as the cause. And this appears as regards both natural things and voluntary things. For some agent, inasmuch as it produces by its power a form to which follows corruption and defect, causes by its power that corruption and defect. But it is manifest that the form which God chiefly intends in things created is the good of the order of the universe. Now, the order of the universe requires that there should be some things that can, and do sometimes, fail. And thus God, by causing in things the good of the order of the universe, consequently and as it were by accident, causes the corruptions of things... And so God is the author of the evil which is penalty, but not of the evil which is fault.

Augustine: Evil as the Absence of Good

From Augustine’s Enchiridion, Chapter 11. Translated by J. F. Shaw, in the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers series (1887).

And in the universe, even that which is called evil, when it is regulated and put in its own place, only enhances our admiration of the good; for we enjoy and value the good more when we compare it with the evil. For the Almighty God, who, as even the heathen acknowledge, has supreme power over all things, being Himself supremely

good, would never permit the existence of anything evil among His works, if He were not so omnipotent and good that He can bring good even out of evil. For what is that which we call evil but the absence of good? In the bodies of animals, disease and wounds mean nothing but the absence of health; for when a cure is effected, that does not mean that the evils which were present — namely, the diseases and wounds — go away from the body and dwell elsewhere: they altogether cease to exist; for the wound or disease is not a substance, but a defect in the fleshly substance — the flesh itself being a substance, and therefore something good, of which those evils — that is, privations of the good which we call health — are accidents. Just in the same way, what are called vices in the soul are nothing but privations of natural good.

Augustine: The Good of Free Will

From Augustine's City of God, Book XXII, Chapter 1. Translated by Marcus Dods (1871).

It is He who gave to this intellectual nature free-will of such a kind, that if he wished to forsake God — that is, his blessedness — misery should immediately result. It is He who, when He foreknew that certain angels would in their pride desire to suffice for their own blessedness, and would forsake their great good, did not deprive them of this power, deeming it to be more befitting His power and goodness to bring good out of evil than to prevent the evil from coming into existence. And indeed evil had never been, had not the mutable nature — mutable, though good, and created by the most high God and immutable Good, who created all things good — brought evil upon itself by sin...

It is He who made also man himself upright, with the same freedom of will — an earthly animal, indeed, but fit for heaven if he remained faithful to his Creator, but destined to the misery appropriate to such a nature if he forsook Him. It is He who when He foreknew that man would in his turn sin by abandoning God and breaking His law, did not deprive him of the power of free-will, because He at the same time foresaw what good He Himself would bring out of the evil.

Irenaeus: Why Man Was Not Made Perfect from the Beginning

From Irenaeus, Against Heresies, Book IV, Chapter 38. Translated in the Ante-Nicene Fathers series (1885).

If, however, any one say, "What then? Could not God have exhibited man as perfect from the beginning?" let him know that, inasmuch as God is indeed always the same and unbegotten as respects Himself, all things are possible to Him. But created things must be inferior to Him who created them, from the very fact of their later origin; for it was not possible for things recently created to have been uncreated. But inasmuch as they are not uncreated, for this very reason do they come short of the perfect. Because, as these things are of later date, so are they infantile; so are they unaccustomed to, and unexercised in, perfect discipline. For as it certainly is in the power of a mother to give strong food to her infant, [but she does not do so, as] the child is not yet able to receive more substantial nourishment; so also it was possible for God Himself to have made man perfect from the first, but man could not receive this perfection, being as yet an infant.

After you read: Notice how these four passages divide into three distinct strategies. Aquinas and Augustine's first passage both work on the *nature* of evil itself — arguing that it is not a thing God makes, but an absence, corruption, or penalty that follows from the created order. Augustine's second passage defends a specific kind of good — free will — as valuable enough that God permitted the risk of its misuse; this is the historical root of what philosophers now call the Free Will Defense. Irenaeus takes a different approach entirely, addressing not moral evil but the very fact of human imperfection, by treating it as a stage in a process rather than a flaw in the design; this is the historical root of what is now called the soul-making, or Irenaean, theodicy. None of these fully answers Philo's question from the previous reading. Notice, as you read them against Hume, which parts of his catalogue of suffering each response actually addresses — and which parts, if any, it leaves untouched.